# Prioritising issues

*Given limited time, which parts of the problem deserve our attention first?*



# Today

By the end of today, you will have

**Pruned your issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence, and chosen the two or three branches you will analyse.**

- Rate branches by size of effect and ability to influence.
- Prune low-priority branches with written reasons.
- Distinguish prioritising issues from prioritising interventions.
- Explain satisficing and what it means for a four-week analysis.

**Competencies: B4**

Session plan

| | |
|---|---|
| 10 min | **Opening problem** |
| 20 min | **Concept: pruning** |
| 20 min | **Demonstration: Madhyapur** |
| 35 min | **Activity: the 80/20 challenge** |
| 25 min | **Own case: pruning matrix** |
| 10 min | **Debrief and exit task** |

# Opening problem

- **You have about fifteen hours of research time left. Your issue tree has twelve leaves. What do you do?**

Write down how many leaves you can investigate well, and how you would choose them.

# The pruning matrix

Size of effect if true

Large

Small

Low

High

**Ability to influence**

| | |
|---|---|
| **Context, not the lead**<br>Large effect, beyond the decision-maker's reach. Note it as context. | **Analyse first**<br>Large effect and within reach. Madhyapur: the contract and collection practice. |
| **Prune**<br>Small effect and hard to change. Drop it, with a written reason. | **Quick check**<br>Within reach but small. Note in passing; do not spend days on it. |

Conn and McLean describe pruning the tree this way. Both ratings are provisional: they are hypotheses about effect and influence, and may change with evidence.

# Pruning the Madhyapur tree

| Branch | Size of effect | Ability to influence | Decision |
|---|---|---|---|
| Collection mixes separated waste | Large | High | Analyse first |
| Separated waste has nowhere to go | Large | Medium | Analyse: processing is a precondition |
| Households do not separate at home | Medium | Medium | Keep, narrowed to space and know-how |
| Rules not enforced or rewarded | Medium | High | Quick check on monitoring |
| National prices for recyclables | Medium | Low | Prune: context only |

Every pruned branch gets a reason. A pruned branch can come back if evidence demands it.

# Prioritising issues is not prioritising interventions

## Prioritising issues: now

- Which questions to investigate
- Criteria: size of effect, ability to influence, testability
- Output: a pruned tree

## Prioritising interventions: Week 4

- Which actions to recommend
- Criteria: effectiveness, cost, feasibility, equity
- Output: an options appraisal

**ICE scoring and the impact-effort matrix rank interventions. They belong in Week 4.**

# The 80/20 idea, used honestly

- **Often a few causes account for most of the effect. Look for them, but do not assume the split is 80/20.**

Pareto reasoning is a search strategy, not a law. In public problems, a small group bearing a large harm may matter more than its share of the total.

# A thinker for your case

## Herbert Simon

*Administrative Behavior (1947) and later work on satisficing*

Simon argued that decision-makers are boundedly rational: they cannot consider every option, so they search until they find one that is good enough. He called this satisficing.

The question it puts to your case

**Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?**

Answer it in one sentence in your workbook today.

# Three ways prioritisation goes wrong

1

## Analysing everything

Spreading fifteen hours across twelve leaves gives twelve shallow answers.

2

## Keeping the comfortable branches

Pruning what is hard to research rather than what matters least.

3

## Pruning the equity branch

Dropping a small group's problem because it is small, though the harm is large.

# Activity: The 80/20 challenge

Practise pruning under pressure, and defend what you dropped.

**Scenario**

A municipal health department wants to reduce dengue cases this monsoon. Your pod has a tree with ten leaves: water in construction sites; household water storage; blocked drains; late case reporting by private clinics; fogging coverage; public awareness; housing for migrant workers; vacancies among surveillance staff; laboratory testing capacity; and coordination between the health and engineering departments.

**What to do**

1. Rate each leaf for size of effect and ability to influence: high, medium or low.
2. Place the leaves on the pruning matrix.
3. Choose three to analyse first; prune at least four, with written reasons.
4. The pod sceptic challenges your weakest pruning decision.
5. Report your three choices and your hardest cut.

**Time** 35 minutes

**Groups** Pods of four

**Output** A pruned tree: three priorities and four written reasons for cuts

# Your case: Worksheet 4.1

## Pruning matrix

1. List the level-two branches of your issue tree.
2. Rate each for size of effect and ability to influence, with a reason.
3. Place them on the matrix.
4. Choose two or three to analyse; prune the rest with written reasons.
5. Check that you have not pruned a branch only because it affects a small or voiceless group.

**Hand in**

Worksheet 4.1 by the start of Day 9.

**Quality check**

Every branch is rated on both dimensions, with reasons.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

# What to take away

1. You cannot analyse everything. Choose deliberately and write down why.
2. Rate branches by size of effect and ability to influence.
3. Prioritising issues now is different from prioritising interventions in Week 4.
4. Check that pruning has not quietly removed a small group bearing a large harm.

**Exit task** Name the branch you pruned that you most expect to regret.

# Before the next session

### Independent work

For each priority branch, write the one or two questions that, if answered, would most change your recommendation. About 40 minutes.

### Read

Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), the chapter on prioritisation and pruning the tree.

---

### Next

## Day 9: Hypotheses

Tomorrow your priority branches become testable hypotheses, and you defend them in the Hypothesis Battle.